

Let's move onto the next step: writing a family mission statement.

SET YOUR PRIORITIES WITH A FAMILY MISSION STATEMENT

The elder Bonner thinks this may be a waste of time. Still, following the advice in the guidebooks, this is what we've done: written a mission statement. The idea is that successful families need a simple statement of purpose that everyone can get behind. Drafting the family mission statement is one of the first tasks of your Family Council. The family mission statement should motivate your family members to want to be a part of the family office project. All the other soft structures you put in place should center on this document.

The family mission statement is supposed to give your family a shared sense of direction. (Of course, if it doesn't have a shared sense of direction already, writing out something is probably not going to help.) More important than the mission statement itself may be the act of trying to write one. It may show you that you don't really have a mission or a unified idea about what you're trying to do.

Aim to draft your family mission statement at your first Family Council meeting. Then take it to the rest of your family. It is crucial that your family mission statement sound right to everyone. Make sure it reflects the genuine values of the family and makes clear the benefits of a family office structure for each family member. If there is disagreement about the mission statement—or if you are unable to come up with a statement that satisfies your family—you are probably doomed.

The first meeting is especially important because it sets the tone for all that comes after it. During this process, it is important to remember that disagreements can be healthy. Issues are coming to the surface, and opinions are being expressed. Remember: *For your family mission statement to bring your family together, it has to include everyone—even family members who appear not to “fit in.” Try to bring all family members into the process.*